Topic 7: Introduction to APIs

AI Automation & Workflow Integration Module

What is an API?

An **API (Application Programming Interface)** allows different software applications to communicate and exchange data. In the modern digital landscape, no application exists in a vacuum. APIs serve as the critical bridges that allow distinct systems—such as your CRM, an AI language model, and your email client—to talk to one another seamlessly without requiring human intervention.



Figure 1: The Request-Response cycle of a typical RESTful API.

The Restaurant Analogy

The easiest way to understand an API is to think of a restaurant. You (the client) are sitting at a table with a menu of choices. The kitchen (the server) is where your food is prepared. However, you do not go into the kitchen to cook the food yourself.

Instead, you rely on the waiter—the API. The waiter takes your specific order (the request), brings it to the kitchen, and then returns to your table with your finished meal (the response). The API abstracts away the complexity of the kitchen, providing you with exactly what you asked for through a standardized interface.

Core API Building Blocks

To successfully integrate AI models and external software into your workflows, you must understand the fundamental components that make up an API transaction.

1. Request and Response

Every API interaction is a two-way street. The **Request** is the package of data and instructions you send to the server (e.g., "Summarize this text"). The **Response** is the server's reply containing the requested data or the result of the operation.

2. API Endpoint

An endpoint is the specific digital address (URL) where an API receives requests. Just as a business has different phone extensions for Sales and Support, an API has different endpoints for different functions (e.g., `/v1/chat/completions` vs. `/v1/images/generations`).

3. JSON Data

JSON (JavaScript Object Notation) is the standard language APIs use to communicate. It structures data in a highly organized format using "key-value" pairs, making it easy for both humans to read and machines to parse when sending prompts to AI.

4. API Keys & Auth

An API Key is a unique, secret token used for **Authentication**. It acts as your digital ID badge, proving to the server that you have authorized access and allowing the provider to track your usage and billing.

Example: Registration API Request

A registration application sends student details to a backend API. The server validates the request and returns an appropriate response. The JSON payload looks like this:

```
{
  "name": "Aarav Patel",
  "course": "Generative AI",
  "email": "aarav@example.com"
}
```

> **Important Security Notice**
> Students should always use sample information for exercises and must **never expose API keys** in public code repositories. Treat your API keys like highly sensitive passwords.

HTTP Methods (The Verbs)

When you send a request to an endpoint, you use an HTTP method to tell the server what action you want to perform.

Method	Action	Typical Use Case in Automation
GET	Retrieve data	Fetching a list of customers from a CRM.
POST	Create data	Sending a prompt to an AI model to generate text.
PUT	Replace data	Updating an entire user profile with new information.
PATCH	Update data	Changing a single field, like a task status to "Done".
DELETE	Remove data	Deleting a temporary file from cloud storage.

Status Codes & Error Responses

After processing your request, the server returns a 3-digit HTTP Status Code. This code immediately tells your automation whether the task succeeded or if an **Error Response** occurred, allowing your workflow to branch logically.

- **2xx (Success):** E.g., *200 OK*. The request was received, understood, and processed successfully.
- **4xx (Client Error):** You made a mistake. Common errors include *401 Unauthorized* (invalid or missing API key) and *429 Too Many Requests* (you hit the provider's rate limit).
- **5xx (Server Error):** E.g., *500 Internal Server Error*. The API provider is experiencing a crash or downtime; your request was valid, but they cannot process it right now.

> **Key Takeaway for Automation**
>
> Modern low-code platforms handle the complex coding of HTTP methods automatically. Your main job is to provide the correct API Key, choose the right endpoint, format your JSON payload correctly, and build logic to handle potential 4xx or 5xx error codes.

Topic 8: Introduction to Webhooks

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What is a Webhook?

While an API generally requires your system to actively ask for data, a **webhook** is entirely event-driven. It automatically sends information to a specified URL the moment a particular event occurs. This "push" mechanism makes webhooks incredibly efficient for real-time workflows and automation triggers.

The Webhook Workflow

1. **Event Occurs:** A specific trigger happens in the source application.

↓

2. **Webhook Sends Data:** The application automatically pushes data to your URL.

↓

3. **Server Receives Request:** Your designated endpoint catches the incoming data.

↓

4. **Validate Event:** The server checks the payload to ensure it is legitimate.

↓

5. **Execute Action:** Your system performs the appropriate downstream task.

Real-World Example: Payment Status

When a payment provider reports a successful payment, it doesn't wait for you to ask. Instead, it instantly sends an event payload to your application's webhook endpoint. Your order system receives this trigger and immediately updates the order status to "Paid", allowing fulfillment to begin.

Technical Format

Under the hood, webhooks rely on the exact same architecture as APIs. They commonly use standard

HTTP POST requests

to deliver their information, formatting the transmitted data as

JSON payloads

Topic 9: AI Prompting Inside Workflows

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Automated AI Steps

In modern workflows, AI isn't just a standalone chatbot; it acts as an intelligent processing node within a larger automated sequence. By sending highly specific prompts via an API, you can force the AI to process incoming data and return strictly formatted results that the next step in your workflow can understand.

The System Prompt

> *"You are a customer support assistant. Read the customer message below and categorize it as Billing, Delivery, Technical Support, or General Inquiry. Return a short summary and the category in JSON format. Do not invent missing information."*

Input

Customer Message:
"Where is my package? The tracking says it was supposed to be here yesterday, but I haven't received anything yet."

Output (JSON Payload)

```
{
  "category": "Delivery",
  "summary": "The customer reports a delayed shipment."
}
```

Critical: Validation and Error Handling

AI models are probabilistic, meaning they can sometimes return malformed data or hallucinate formats. Students designing automated workflows **must always validate the response structure** before passing it to the next step. Ensure your automation logic handles missing keys, invalid values, or non-JSON text gracefully to prevent the entire workflow from crashing.

Topic 10: Conditions and Branching

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Workflow Logic

Conditions allow an automated workflow to take different actions based on the specific input data or the result of a previous step. Instead of a rigid, linear sequence, branching logic enables dynamic, intelligent responses to real-world variability.

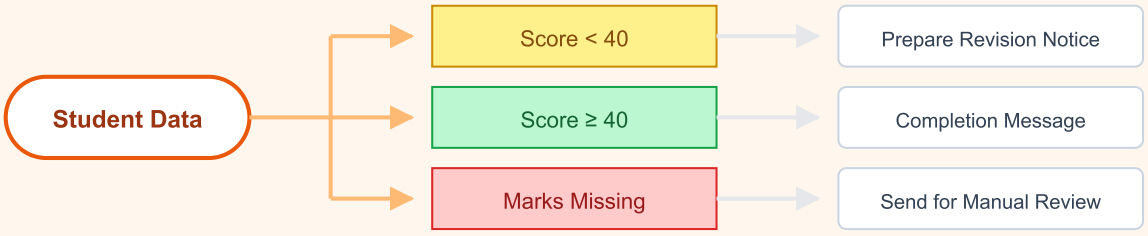


Figure 2: Branching logic based on student score evaluation.

Example: Student Assessment Rules

If student score is below 40:

Trigger the "needs improvement" branch to automatically generate and email a revision notice to the student.

If the score is 40 or above:

Trigger the "success" branch to prepare a completion message and issue the module certificate.

If marks are missing:

Trigger the "exception" branch to suspend automated processing and send the record to an instructor for manual review.

Topic 11: Error Handling and Workflow Reliability

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Why Automations Fail

Even perfectly designed workflows will occasionally encounter issues in the real world. Automations commonly fail due to invalid input data, temporary network outages, expired API credentials, provider rate limits, or unexpected and unformatted responses from AI models. Designing for reliability means expecting these failures and handling them gracefully.

Essential Reliability Practices

1. Validation & Checks

- **Validate incoming data:** Ensure all required information is present before starting.
- **Handle missing fields:** Provide default values or alternative routing for empty data.

2. Execution Logic

- **Check status codes:** Verify API success (e.g., 200 OK) before moving to the next step.
- **Add retry rules:** Automatically retry tasks if failures are due to temporary network hiccups.

3. Safety & Logging

- **Prevent duplicates:** Ensure a retried step doesn't accidentally charge a customer twice.
- **Record in a log:** Save exact error details and payloads for later debugging.

4. Notification & Testing

- **Notify a human:** Alert a responsible team member when a critical task fails definitively.
- **Test before deployment:** Always use sample data to thoroughly verify edge cases.

Build for Resilience

An automated workflow is only as strong as its error handling. By proactively intercepting invalid inputs and monitoring API status codes, you prevent a minor glitch from snowballing into a critical system failure.